



Males and females

REPRODUCTION IS THE HALLMARK OF LIFE – a vital part of the cycle of living things. In the human species, reproduction is much the same as for any other mammal. Specialized reproductive organs are in the lower abdomen. The male has glands called testes that make microscopic, tadpole-shaped sperm cells. The female has glands called ovaries that make pinpoint-sized egg cells. To begin a new life, a sperm cell must fertilize an egg cell, and sexual intercourse brings these cells together. Pioneer scientific anatomists such as Leonardo da Vinci and Andreas Vesalius treated the sexual organs like any other parts of the body, making careful dissections and increasingly accurate depictions. Yet through history, there have been varying and inaccurate views of the reproductive organs and of mating. Aristotle, for example, denied any female contribution to a “soul.” Some societies regard sexual acts as a natural, unremarkable aspect of life. Other cultures surround sex with taboos, keep it furtive, secret, and suppressed, or even worship it.

BEGINNER'S GUIDE

In the 1540s, Andreas Vesalius (p. 10) presented the typical male and female human bodies in his book *Epitome*. The male is generally more muscular than the female, with wide shoulders and narrow hips, and more facial and body hair. The female overall contours are rounded by pads of body fat, particularly around the thighs and abdomen, with wide hips and developed breasts. *Epitome* was intended as a “beginner’s” guide to anatomy. The drawings identified the external features of the body.

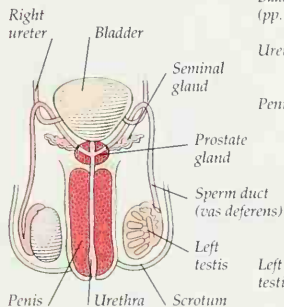
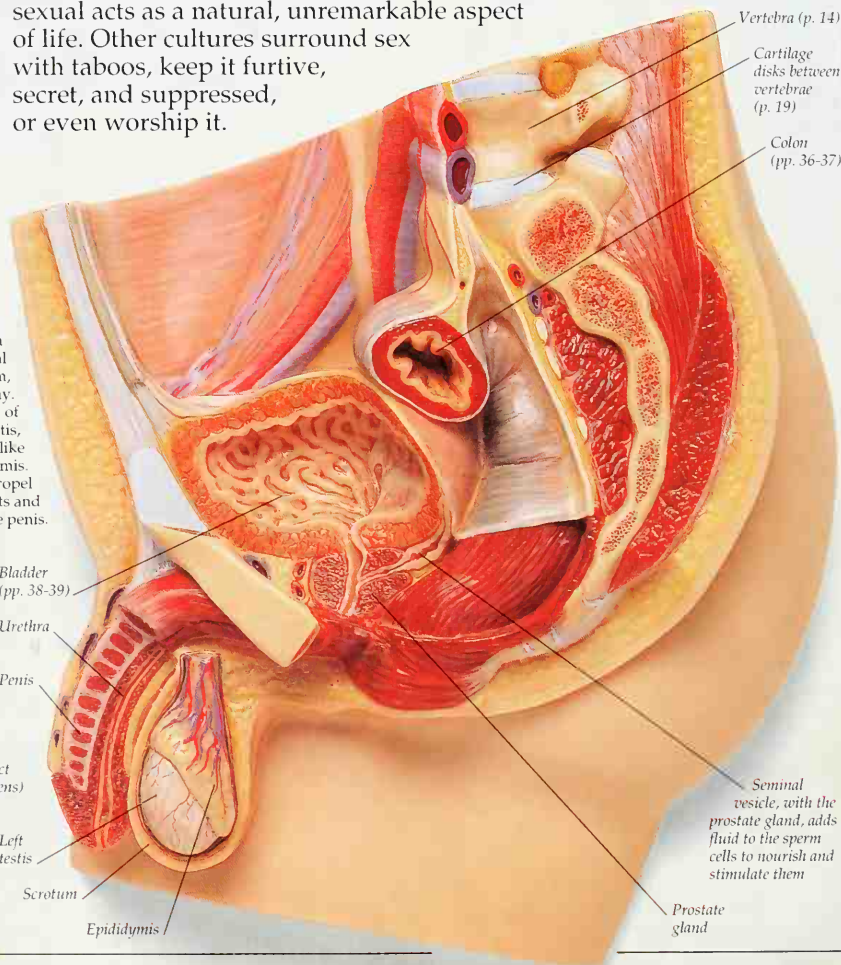
MALE REPRODUCTIVE ORGANS

The model shows a cutaway view of the male reproductive system.

It is closely linked to the urinary system (pp. 38-39), as the urethra inside the penis is a tube for both urine and sperm cells. The two oval testes in their skin bag, the scrotum, make millions of sperm every day.

These are stored in 547 yd (500 m) of tiny, tightly coiled tubes in each testis, and in the 6.6-yd (6-m), spaghetti-like tangle of tubes forming the epididymis.

During sex, muscle contractions propel the sperm along the sperm ducts and urethra and out of the penis.



Front view of male reproductive system